

create a style. For example, the crisp outline of *Juniperus communis* 'Compressa' suits a formal design, while the shape, flowers, and fruit of many crabapples (*Malus* species) lend natural informality.

If you have space for several trees, you can create a small woodland, underplanted with shade-loving perennials. Many small trees, such as *Acer palmatum* and the corkscrew hazel (*Corylus avellana* 'Contorta'), and dwarf conifers are also suitable for growing in containers, and will add height and interest to patios, decks, and roof gardens.

Year-round interest

Broadleaf evergreens, such as hollies (*Ilex*) and bay laurel (*Laurus nobilis*), provide a valuable green backdrop throughout the year, while the needlelike foliage and candlelike cones of conifers offer a useful contrast in shape and texture. Against this

permanent display, plant deciduous trees for a seasonally changing palette of leaf colors, flowers, and fruit. Japanese cherries (*Prunus*), crabapples (*Malus*) and magnolias have vivid spring flowers, while many trees have large, dramatic leaves or colorful foliage that brightens up the summer garden. A few trees, such as *Maackia amurensis* and *Arbutus unedo*, bear flowers in late summer and fall, but in the case of Japanese maples (*Acer*), the Chinese tupelo (*Nyssa sinensis*), and liquidambar, fall foliage color is the main attraction; they produce luminous colors that set the garden ablaze.

Stem and bark color is a key feature of winter displays. The bleached white trunks of birches (*Betula*), glossy copper stems of *Prunus serrula*, and shaggy bark of *Acer griseum* provide focal points, while the dainty pink flowers of *Prunus x subhirtella* 'Autumnalis' lift late-winter days.



ABOVE Spring benefits

The profusion of large, double pink flowers of *Prunus serrulata* 'Kiku-shidare-sakura' makes a dramatic and colorful focal point in a spring garden.

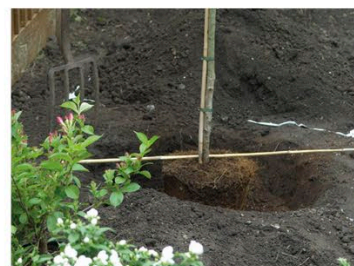
PLANTING A CONTAINER-GROWN TREE

It is worth taking the time to prepare the site and plant your tree well, as this will increase its chances of survival, and ensure that it thrives. Trees that have been grown in containers can be planted at most times of the year,

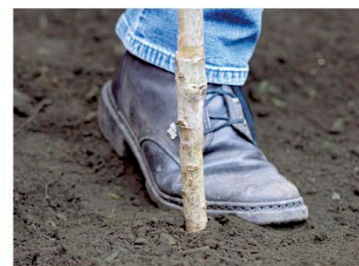
but the warm, damp soil in fall provides ideal conditions. Bare-root trees are cheaper and available in fall or late winter. Plant them as soon as you get them home, unless the soil is frozen.



1 Break up the soil
Dig a hole twice the width of the pot and the same depth as the tree's rootball. Do not dig over the bottom of the hole as this may cause the tree to sink once planted. Instead, use a fork to puncture the base and sides.



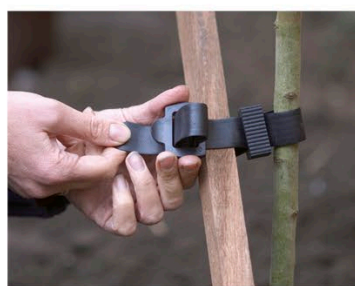
2 Check planting depth
Remove the tree from its pot and put it in the hole. Use a cane to check that the top of the rootball is at the same level or slightly above the soil. Lift out the plant and cut away any roots that are circling the root ball.



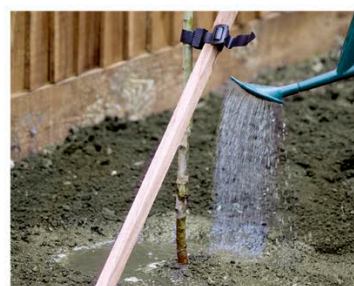
3 Firm in
Tease out the roots, lower the tree back into the hole, and water it well. Then water again as you backfill the hole to ensure that there are no air pockets and the roots are in no danger of drying out. Firm the tree in gently.



4 Stake the tree
To prevent the tree from rocking in the wind, which can damage the roots, drive in a wooden tree stake with a mallet at an angle of 45 degrees. Make sure the stake does not damage the root ball.



5 Attach the tree ties
Ensure that the top of the stake faces into the prevailing wind. Place a tree tie with a spacer one-third of the way up the trunk from the base. Drive a nail through the tree tie into the stake to stop it from slipping down.



6 Continue to water in well
Water the tree well and apply a moisture-conserving bark mulch over the area around the tree, leaving a space clear around the stem to prevent the mulch from rotting it. Water the tree during dry spells for 2 years.

BARE-ROOT TREES

If the ground is frozen when you receive your bare-root trees, or you are unable to plant them immediately for some other reason, fill a large pot with potting mix and heel them in. This simply means burying the roots to keep them moist. Plant the trees in the same way as shown here for container-grown plants, but take care to leave no air pockets when filling in around the roots with soil.